victory. The Mirzas, meanwhile, regrouped at a safe distance: Ibrahim, his brother Muhammad Husain and their relative Shah Mirza convened in Idar, far to the north. Here, having never managed to sustain an alliance, whether with the Uzbeks or any Gujarati chiefs, the three men fell out with each other, too.[28] Ibrahim decided to march alone upon Agra, no less; while the other two resumed plotting with the Fuladi chiefs of Gujarat.

Akbar, meanwhile, arrived in the port city of Surat, 'thronged with merchants, and . . . full of ships'.[29] The city – with Mirza Ibrahim's wife and children amongst its population – was held by Ibrahim's men, and Akbar's troops had been camped outside the Surat fort for some time. 'Every hole big enough for a mouse was closed,' writes Nizamuddin. Even so, Ibrahim's wife, Kamran's daughter Gulrukh, evidently possessed something of her father's daredevilry. She had escaped Surat with her two small children, a boy and a girl, and fled to the Deccan, pursued by imperial soldiers whom 'that wise woman . . . got away from'.[30]

One of the children, Gulrukh's two-year-old daughter, was captured on the way and brought back to Surat, and to Akbar, who had reached the harbour city. With her was another, less innocent captive – that old rebel Sharafuddin.

Ever since his failed insurrection, Sharafuddin, once Akbar's brother-in-law, had been lurking on the borders of Akbar's expanding realm. He had attempted alliances with Chenghis Khan, with the Mirzas, even with the Deccani kingdom of Khandesh – until he fell into the hands of the chieftain of Baglana, a buffer zone between Gujarat and Khandesh, whose ruler had adopted the wise policy of siding with 'whichever of the two is the stronger'.[31] Now, with a third and vastly more powerful force at his door, Baglana's lord offered Akbar his two bargaining chips: Sharafuddin and the child princess.[32]

Sharafuddin was put in chains; and the young girl in Akbar's harem, which wasn't far away. It was routine for the padishah's family to travel with his army; now, the women's tents were pitched by a tank called Gopi Talao, shielded from the firing from Surat's walls by a cover of trees and undulating land. Akbar's first Rajput queen, Harkha Bai, was amongst them with her son Salim, who now had two brothers. One was Murad, nicknamed 'Pahadi' because he was born upon a hill. Salim and Murad were about